



The team at ElectroMech Corporation

to do. If you feel coding still interests you, then take the support of fellow developers to learn it.

Q. How do you shortlist a project you would like to contribute to?

A. You need to understand your top few interest areas and then do your research on the projects happening around them. You need to figure out the area of requirements or openings for contributors and more volunteers. You can start small to practice and then build expertise.

Avoid going by the trendy topics; what's important is your individual interest. For instance, DevOps is in high demand now and you may tend to go for a DevOps project. Do not make this mistake.

You can find open source projects on Cloud Native Computing Foundation (CNCF), Apache, Fedora, Red Hat, and so on. This way you

can also find mentors who are already working on projects and can get proper guidance.

Q. Projects have their own purpose and target audience. Sometimes they even misalign with open source goals. So, what does one check before contributing?

A. I agree it becomes challenging when somebody starts an open source project and then commercialises it. But this is always a risk, and should not discourage you.

First try to check out the group — how popular are the contributors working in the group, how long have they been contributing, and how reputed are they. And once you join, observing everyone and everything is the key. Try to learn at least for three to six months, and understand how everything works. You can always leave the project if you find the intention is wrong. But if you feel it's all right, then go ahead and contribute.

There are certain licence checks that you can do, say, like GPL version 3. You can also look at unmodified licence versions like the Apache open source licence.

Q. Do you think big companies will accept contributions from freshers?

A. Yes, of course. Companies also like mentoring. They usually don't allow you to contribute directly, but may give you a small assignment initially. A mentor will first try to understand what skill you have and how good you are at it. Once they recognise you have the kind of skill that is needed, they will continue to guide you or assign you to some other mentor based on your skill. The initial stages are very crucial. Many companies do some sort of screening, and you may be allowed to contribute only after you have proved your ability.